

ACT Compass for Coaching and Therapy

COMPANION WORKBOOK

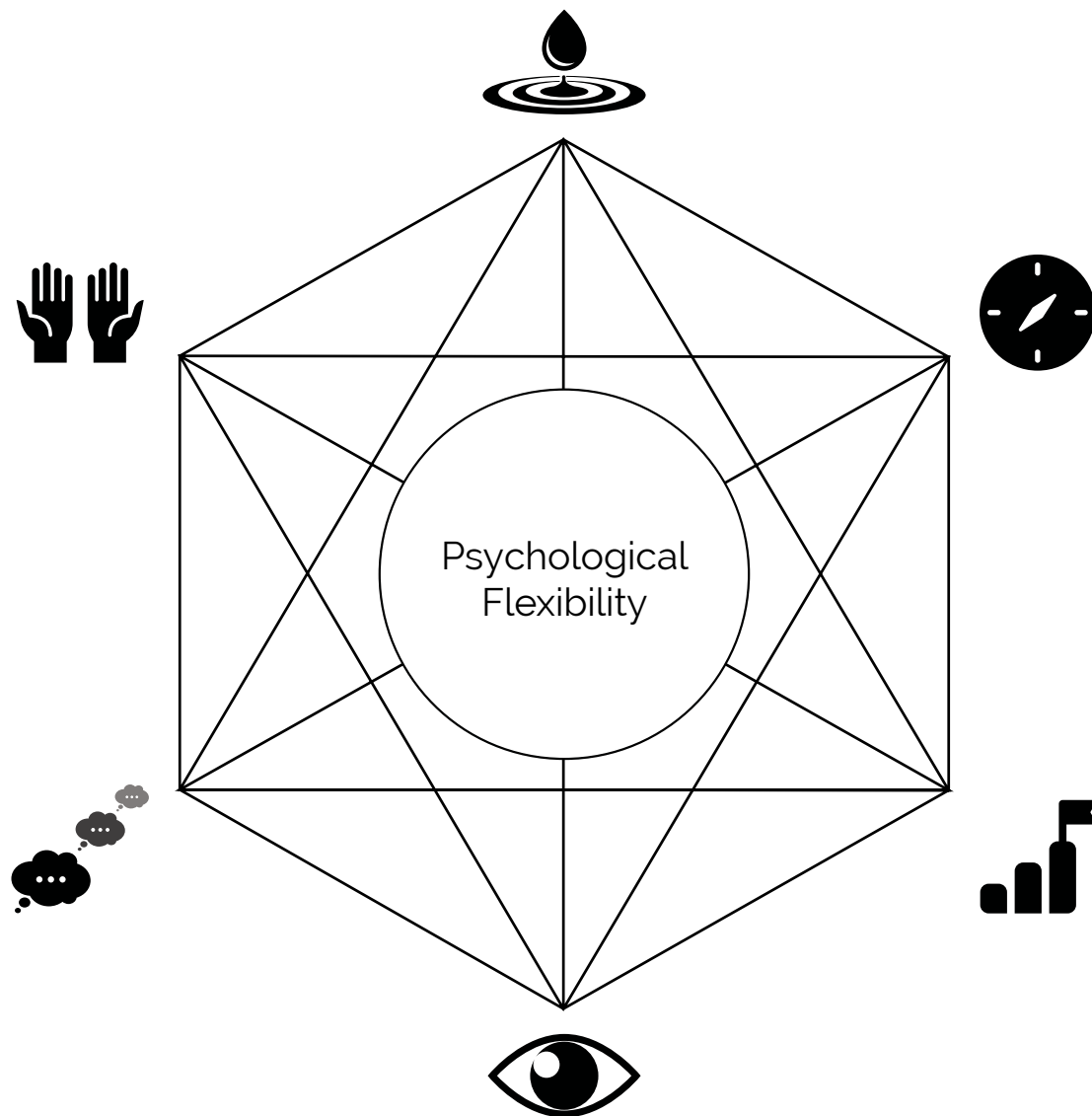


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ACT Toward a Rich, Full, and Meaningful Life

What would you do if today was the last day of your life?

It is easy to forget we'll die one day. This is understandable because we get caught up in many things—difficult thoughts demanding our full attention, painful feelings we're avoiding, self-defeating actions we're repeatedly engaging in.

We're stuck in a loop. We forget our time is limited. We don't act toward the life we truly want to live.

Acceptance and Commitment Therapy, or ACT, empowers us to get unstuck. ACT helps us learn mindfulness skills to lessen the impact and influence of our psychological barriers so that we can act effectively toward a rich, full, and meaningful life.

The good news is that ACT is for everyone—coaches, therapists, and clients. When coaches and therapists do ACT in their personal lives, they become better guides for their clients because they can deeply empathize and go through similar experiences.

For anyone interested in or curious about ACT, we offer you the ACT Compass, a handy guide to use in your coaching or therapy sessions, or a helpful tool and overview for practicing ACT. In this companion workbook, you can discover more experiential exercises, learn about the content and features of the ACT Compass, and explore additional resources for your practice.

We wish you vitality in life and your sessions!

More Exercises for Your Sessions

Cognitive Defusion (Watch your thinking)

Name that Story

- **Pause and observe** the thoughts you're having. Notice them without judgment or the need to analyze them.
- **Ask** yourself, "What's the story my mind is telling me right now?" Summarize it in a sentence or two. You can say, "My mind is telling me the story that I'm never going to be enough."
- **Imagine** you're an author or a director and give your mind's story a title, e.g., "The 'I'm Not Enough' Story."
- **Say** to yourself, "Oh, this is the 'I'm Not Enough' Story my mind is telling me." or "Ah, there's that 'I'm Not Enough' Story again." Identify the story every time you're having the same thoughts.
- **Recognize** that it's just a story, not facts or an absolute truth. Notice the separation you've created from your thoughts simply by naming them.
- **Optional:** Be creative with your story titles. Make it memorable, witty, or funny if that helps you create distance with your thoughts. Some example story titles:
 - "The Perfectionist's Dilemma"
 - "The Worrywart's Whirlwind Adventure"
 - "The Guilt Trip Chronicles"
 - "Lonely Island: The Solo Survivor Edition"
 - "The 'Shoulda, Coulda, Woulda' Script"

The Problem-Solving Machine

- **Notice** when your mind shifts into its problem-solving mode. Recognize that it's simply doing what it evolved to do—solve problems.
- **Identify** the problem your mind is trying to solve. Is it a practical issue (e.g., planning your meals for the week) or an emotional issue (e.g., overthinking future scenarios to try to avoid feeling anxious)?
- **Acknowledge** that your mind is a problem-solving machine trying to keep you safe and free from pain. You can say, "There's the problem-solving machine at work again." or "My mind's in its problem-solving mode again." When you label what your mind is doing, you can create some distance from your thoughts.
- **Evaluate** the solution your mind is proposing, especially for emotional issues. Ask: "Is this solution effective in the long run?", "Will it contribute to a rich and full life, or is it just a quick fix?", "Is this action aligned with my values and what matters to me?"

Experiential Acceptance (Open up)

Willing to be Human

- **Ground** yourself in the present moment. Settle into a comfortable position. Plant your feet on the ground or the floor. Breathe deeply and close your eyes.
- **Scan** your body from head to toe. Notice any sensations that stand out to you—tightness, warmth, tingling, or any other feeling. Simply observe these sensations without labeling them as good or bad.
- **Choose** one area of your body where a sensation feels particularly strong. Focus on this sensation and notice its qualities. Is it constant or does it change? Does it have a specific shape or boundary? Are there variations in intensity or temperature?

- **Acknowledge** what you're feeling by saying something like, "I notice a tightness in my chest, which accompanies my feelings of anger." or "I'm aware of this warmth in my stomach that comes when I'm feeling happy." You can use the [Emotions Compass](#) or "[How do you feel?](#)" [Coaching Cards](#) to help you name sensations and feelings.



- **Stay** with the sensation and emotion, allowing yourself to experience it fully. Let it stay as long as it needs to, and let it go when it's ready.

The Weather Within

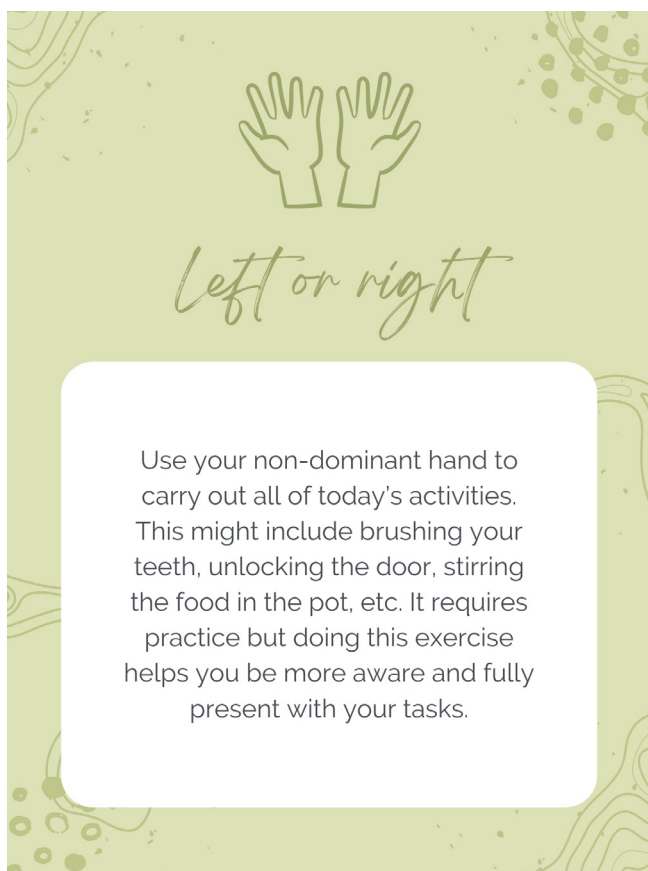
- **Take** a moment to breathe deeply and be in your body. Open up to the sensations you're feeling and the thoughts you're having.
- **Imagine** that your body and mind are like the sky—a vast and expansive space where different types of weather occur.
- **Notice** the "weather" that is present within you right now. Do your emotions and thoughts feel stormy, rainy, or sunny?
- **Identify** the weather that represents your emotions and thoughts. You can say, "In this moment, I'm experiencing a thunderstorm of anger." or "There's a gentle rain of sadness."
- **Allow** your inner weather to exist without trying to change it. Remember that allowing doesn't mean liking or approving of it. When you let the rain be, instead of cursing at it or avoiding it, you can take a walk in the rain to meet a friend or a loved one. Similarly, when you open up to your emotions and thoughts, no matter how unpleasant or painful they may be, you allow yourself to be a normal human being. And by doing so, you can create space to act on what matters to you.

- **Acknowledge** that your inner weather is temporary and it will pass in its own time, just like how a storm eventually gives way to a clear sky.

Contact With the Present Moment (Be here now)

The following mindfulness exercises are from our Mindful Moments card set. Find out more [here](#).

Left or Right



Mindful Eating



Self-as-Context (Pure awareness)

The Observing Self

- **Breathe** deeply for a few moments. Pay attention to the air going in and out of your lungs. Focus on the sensations you're feeling. Observe the thoughts running through your mind.

- **Identify** your feelings and thoughts. Are you having pleasant or unpleasant feelings? Are you planning, analyzing, ruminating, worrying, or fantasizing? Let's call these feelings and thoughts the content of your mind—this part of you is “the thinking self.” Your thinking self always wants to get your full attention.
- **Pay attention** to the part of you that's noticing your feelings and thoughts. Let's call this the context of your mind—this part of you is “the observing self.” Your observing self can make room for all kinds of feelings and thoughts, even the most difficult and painful ones. It's a safe and enduring space inside of you.
- **Observe** how your thoughts and feelings (the content) change from one thing to another, but the part of you that notices them (the context) is always the same. Acknowledge that, while your feelings and thoughts are constantly changing, the part of you that notices them remains constant.

The Inner Lighthouse

- **Imagine** that within you, there is a steady and unwavering lighthouse standing firm on a rocky shore.
- **Picture** the waves crashing against the rocks at the base of the lighthouse. These waves represent your feelings, emotions, thoughts, memories, or any private experience. Notice how they rise and fall, come and go, sometimes gently, sometimes forcefully, but the lighthouse remains solid and enduring.
- **Direct** the light from the lighthouse to shine onto a wave, then another, and yet another. Notice that you can pay attention to any wave you shine the light on while your inner lighthouse remains constant and unchanged.
- **Reflect** on how the light is like your awareness, which you can direct, and how the lighthouse represents your observing self—a safe and enduring place within you that can provide space for any feeling, thought, or private experience.

Values (Know what matters)

From Dreams to Values

- **Remember** a dream or two that you had as a child. What did you want to be when you grew up? What activities or roles excited you? Spend some time remembering your memories.
- **Identify** what values are behind those dreams. For instance, if you dreamed of becoming a veterinarian, you might have valued being empathetic and caring for living beings, particularly animals. Or if you dreamed of becoming a comedian, you might have valued making people laugh and using humor to make sense of life.
- **Use** the ["What Really Matters!" Values Cards](#) to help you identify these values. Lay out the cards in front of you and select the values behind your childhood dreams. If you're unsure what the value is on the card, turn it over for its definition. You might find that a dream is linked to multiple values. It's helpful to phrase your values as statements about how you want to act on an ongoing basis, e.g., respecting nature and living things, connecting with people, being loving and kind, being self-sufficient, and being in control of my finances. This emphasizes that your values are available for you to act on at any moment.



Care for the natural earth and the beings and things in it.



Quality of acting amusing or comical by allowing a change of perspective.

- **Reflect** on how these values show up in your life today. Which values are still important to you? How do they manifest in your current actions, decisions, or goals? You can use the values cards to help you group the values by importance or relevance in your current life.
- **Consider** if there are any childhood values you've lost touch with but would like to reconnect with. Choose one or two values you'd like to reflect again in your life now.
- **Set** an intention to honor these values by thinking of a small action you can take that aligns with them. Keep your selected values cards somewhere visible as a reminder of your intention.

Crafting What Matters to Me

- **Gather** some basic crafting materials, such as old magazines, newspapers, printed images, scissors, glue, paper or a blank notebook, colored pens, markers, crayons, stickers, fabric scraps, small decorative items, and a small object to decorate, such as a jar, a box, or a picture frame.
- **Reflect** on what matters to you in one aspect of life. Choose three to five values that resonate deeply with you in this area. This can be your values in health and well-being, relationships, career and work, personal growth, or leisure and recreation.
- **Select** a handicraft activity that you enjoy. Some options are crafting a collage or vision board, decorating an object, or creating a personalized notebook.
- **Represent** the values you've chosen for your selected handicraft activity. For instance, you can cut out images, words, or phrases from magazines representing your desired values in crafting your collage or vision board. Then, you can arrange and glue them onto a paper or poster board to visually represent what matters to you.
- **Share** your creation with someone you love and trust or display it in a place where you'll see it regularly to help reinforce your connection to your values.

Committed Action (Do what it takes)

Stepping Stones to My Goal

- **Choose** an area of your life where you want to change and the values you want to reflect. For example, taking care of your body and mind and living a healthy and balanced life matter to you, so you'd like to improve your health and well-being.
- **Set** a specific goal you want to achieve to have better health and well-being. Write down your goal clearly and concisely, e.g., "Complete a 5K run by the end of this year.", "Improve sleep quality over the next 3 months.", or "Reduce stress in the next 2 weeks."
- **Imagine** standing at the starting point of a path leading directly to your goal. The path has stepping stones, each representing a key action you need to take to move closer to your goal.
- **Identify** these key actions that will help you achieve your goal. Draw a stepping stone for each action leading to your written goal. Break down each stepping stone if you need to. For example:
 - Goal: Improve sleep quality over the next 3 months.
 - 1st stepping stone: Establish a consistent sleep schedule for weeks 1-2.
 - Set a specific bedtime and wake-up time to ensure 7-8 hours of sleep every night.
 - Set an alarm for both bedtime and wake-up time to stay consistent.
 - Track sleep every day to see if you're sticking to the schedule.
- **Commit** to the first stepping stone. Take an easy or simple action immediately, then move on to the next, and continue in this way.
- **Celebrate** each action you complete. It doesn't have to be grand but can be as simple as checking it off, sharing with a friend or partner, or giving yourself a pat on the back.
- **Continue** committing to the following stepping stones and taking action until you reach your goal.

Mapping My Life Path

- **Choose** three to five core values you want to guide your life. These values will serve as your compass, pointing you in the direction you want to go.
- **Reflect** on your strengths and select the ones you believe will support you in working toward your goals. You can use the ["Stronger You" Strengths Cards](#) or the [Strengths Compass](#) to help you identify your strengths.



- **Draw** a map representing your life journey. Mark your current position, then draw paths leading toward the life you want to create, each one aligned with one of your core values.
- **Place** key milestones along the paths. If this is too much, start with one path and one milestone on that path.
- **Think** about how your strengths can help you achieve your milestones. Make your milestones SMART (specific, meaningful, adaptive, realistic, and time-framed). Write down the details on your map. For example:
 - Core value or Path: Being compassionate to myself and others.
 - Strength: Empathetic
 - SMART Milestone:
 - Specific: Volunteer twice a month at a shelter.
 - Meaningful: Volunteering connects with my value of being compassionate and allows me to use my empathy to help people.
 - Adaptive: If my schedule changes, I'll look for other volunteering opportunities that fit my availability.
 - Realistic: Two monthly volunteer sessions fit into my current commitments.
 - Time-framed: I will track my progress over the next six months.

- **Commit** to taking the first action step toward one milestone today. Choose an action that's easy for you to do. Take the next step, then the next ones, until you build a pattern of acting to fulfill your milestone. Celebrate every action done.
- **Reflect** on your progress and adjust your milestones as your situation changes.
- **Place** your life map where you can always see it. This will inspire you to keep acting toward the rich, full, and meaningful life you're creating.

About the ACT Compass

The ACT Compass supports you in helping clients act toward a values-driven and vital life. The ACT Compass has something to offer whether you're a seasoned practitioner, just starting, or working on your personal development.

Let's dive into how to use it in your sessions and make the most of its features.

Content and Features

The ACT Compass is an A4-laminated print that you can easily bring and use in your sessions. On one side, you'll find a handy guide for Psychological Flexibility, and on the other, for Psychological Inflexibility.

Psychological Flexibility / Psychological Inflexibility

On the "Psychological Flexibility" page, you'll find the six therapeutic processes with representative icons to visualize them. You can facilitate an experiential exercise in the "Step-by-Step Exercises" column for each process. To help you check whether the client is experiencing a process, the "Checklists (✓)" column provides assessment guides.

Turn the print over, and you'll find the six pathological processes and their representative icons on the "Psychological Inflexibility" page. For each process, the "Reflective Questions" column lists questions you can ask to understand your client's situation and therapy needs. This page's "Cross-Out Lists (X)" column provides assessment guides for each pathological process.

Therapeutic Processes / Pathological Processes

You can quickly compare the therapeutic and pathological processes by simply turning the page over. To readily locate the opposing processes, they are placed back to back and color-coded in bright and dull shades of the same color. For example, "Committed Action" and "Unworkable Action" are colored bright teal and dull teal, respectively.

The order of the therapeutic processes in the compass (starting from Cognitive Defusion and ending with Committed Action) mirrors the traditional ACT protocol, i.e., how ACT practitioners traditionally introduce the ACT Hexaflex in their therapy sessions. However, you can start from any therapeutic process, depending on what could work best for your client.

Step-by-Step Exercises

Help your client learn mindfulness skills by facilitating the suggested experiential exercises. You can read or modify the step-by-step instructions (change the wording, include descriptions or examples, add or omit steps, etc.) as you go. Find more exercises for each process in the “More Exercises for Your Sessions” section above. Alternatively, use different exercises altogether that could work better for your client.

Reflective Questions

Ask the example questions to elicit which specific psychological barriers the client struggles with and to deepen self-awareness. You can modify the questions as needed.

- **Cognitive Fusion | Hooked by the mind:** Ask these questions to find out what kinds of thoughts the client fuses with. The questions focus on fusion in these key areas:
 - *rules*, e.g., “I must always do things perfectly.”, “I shouldn’t be feeling scared to do this.”
 - *reasons*, e.g., “I’m too busy.”, “I can’t change.”
 - *judgments*, e.g., “Life sucks.”, “People can’t be trusted.”
 - *the remembered past and imagined future*, e.g., “If only I had made a different choice back then.”, “Things will just get worse tomorrow.”
 - *self-identity*, e.g., “I’m a failure.”, “I’m a bad parent.” (Harris, 2009).
- **Experiential Avoidance | Running away from pain:** Ask these questions to reveal the client’s control strategies. The questions are about the most common control strategies DOTS, an acronym for:
 - *distractions*, e.g., doomscrolling on social media, binge-watching shows,
 - *opting out*, e.g., avoiding socializing, withdrawing from people,

- *thinking strategies*, e.g., denial, positive thinking, analyzing, blaming others, self-criticism, problem-solving,
- *self-harm*, e.g., cutting, suicide attempts, and reckless behavior (Harris, 2009).

You can also ask questions about *substances*, e.g., food, alcohol, cigarettes, drugs, prescription medication, or *other strategies*, e.g., excessive sleeping (Harris, 2009).

- **Limited Self-Knowledge | Stuck in the past or future:** Ask these questions to discover what thoughts and feelings about the remembered past or imagined future the client gets lost in. These can be thoughts on past failures, rejections, losses, abuses, or worries or fantasies about the bad or good things that haven't happened yet.
- **Attachment to the Perceived Self | Rigid sense of self:** Ask these questions to uncover which stories about the conceptualized self the client is attached to, such as "I'm stupid." or "I'm a good person." Alternatively, you can also ask about the beliefs, thoughts, ideas, facts, images, judgments, and memories the client holds on tightly to.

An example behavior of this pathological process is difficulty in perspective-taking, e.g., the client struggles to understand or consider other people's points of view and often sticks to their own opinions.

- **Lack of Values Clarity or Contact | Disconnected from what matters:** Ask these questions to discern if the client's actions and values are not aligned. Some telltale actions indicating the lack of values clarity or contact:
 - Constantly seeking approval and validation from others.
 - Unthinkingly following what your peers say you should do.
- **Unworkable Action | Unhelpful behavior:** Ask these questions to detect the client's barriers to action. The most common psychological barriers are FEAR, which stands for:
 - *fusion* with reasons like "I can't do it." or "It's too hard.",

- *excessive goals* that are impossible to achieve given the client's present circumstance, e.g., goals that exceed their current resources such as skills, time, money, physical health, etc.,
- *avoidance of discomfort* or the client's unwillingness to accept discomfort, e.g., unpleasant feelings like anxiety, as they make life changes,
- *remoteness from values* which shows when the client (a) is unable or unwilling to connect with their values, (b) confuses rules or morals with their values, (c) talks about their values but doesn't truly connect with them, and (d) gives the values of their parents, culture, religion, etc. instead of their own (Harris, 2009).

Checklists (✓) and Cross-Out Lists (X)

The checklists and cross-out lists contain an itemized list for every therapeutic and pathological process. The items on each list are key characteristics or signs that one is experiencing the process.

Because many of these characteristics are private experiences (e.g., "You notice the 'observing self'—the part of you that notices thoughts, feelings, memories, sensations, etc."), collaborating closely with the client is essential for assessing their current state and determining which intervention to focus on.

The second-person point of view (i.e., you, your) allows you to simply read the items out loud to your client for self-assessment if they are open to it.

Workability

Workability is the guiding principle of ACT. We always ask, "Is what you're doing working to make your life rich, full, and meaningful?" (Harris, 2009). This question can help the client reorient and see which actions are helpful and workable for them and which are not.

Similarly, workability can be your anchor or North Star in your ACT practice as a coach or therapist. In moments of doubt or uncertainty, you can always ask, "Is what we're doing in this session helping the client take workable actions for their life?"

RESOURCES

THE ACT HEXAFLEX

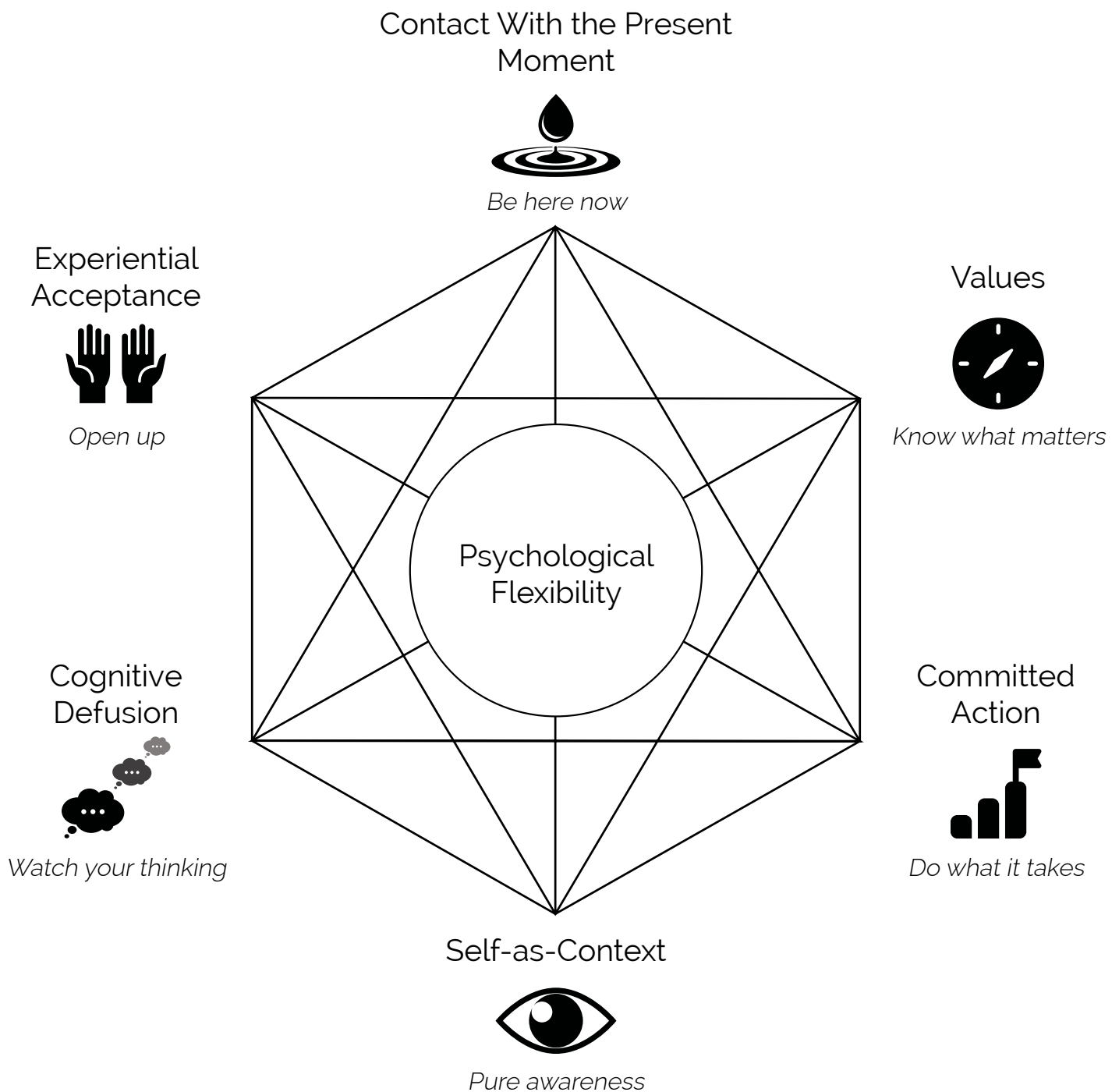


Illustration adapted from *ACT Made Simple* by Dr. Russ Harris.

PSYCHOPATHOLOGY FROM THE ACT PERSPECTIVE

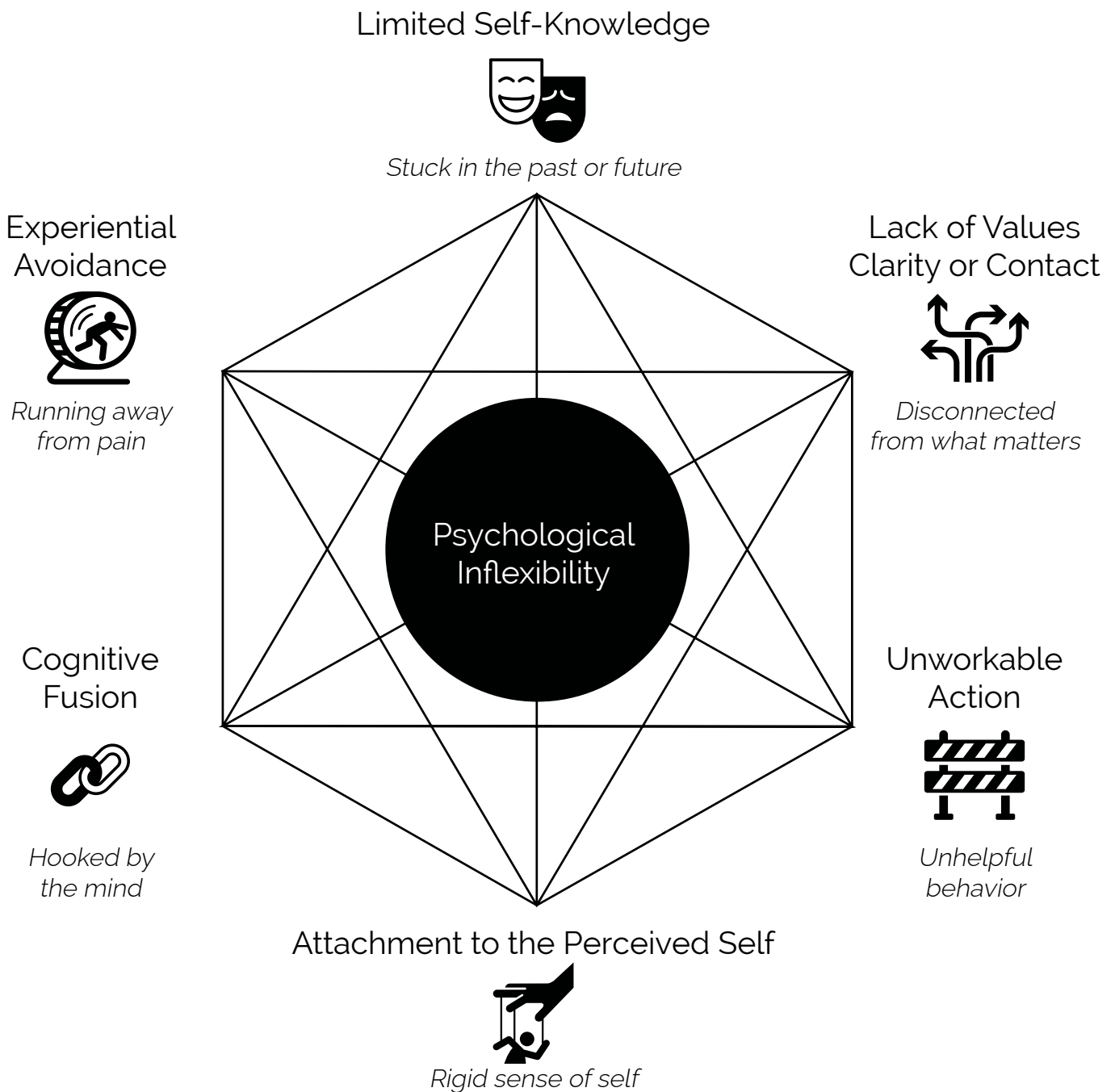


Illustration adapted from *ACT Made Simple* by Dr. Russ Harris.

REFERENCE

Harris, R. (2009). *ACT made simple: An easy-to-read primer on Acceptance and Commitment Therapy*. New Harbinger Publications.

ABOUT METAFOX

Vision

A world embracing emotional intelligence.

At metaFox, we believe that emotional intelligence is the basis for inner and outer peace. Self-awareness and social skills foster individual happiness and meaningful relationships in life and work. This is what we strive for.

Mission

Provide empowering tools for people development.

Being aware of one's emotional state, values, strengths, and beliefs forms the basis for a meaningful and happy life. At metaFox, we enable the development of the necessary skills and mindset by providing tools for emotional health and personal growth to people development professionals as well as personal development enthusiasts.

Our Values



Trust

We foster an environment of openness, empathy, and transparency, enabling decentralized decision-making.



Impact

We strive for meaningful impact in what we do by embracing simplicity and improving iteratively.



Personal Growth

We continuously learn new things, give supportive feedback, and embrace development and healing.



Dedication

We are committed to our work and each other, and proactively seek opportunities for improvement and change.

Contact Us

We'd love to hear from you! We welcome and appreciate your feedback on and personal experience with our products. We're open to collaborating with you. If you have a product idea you'd like to develop with us, please reach out.

Email: hello@metaFox.eu | **Website:** www.metaFox.eu

metaFox GmbH | Carl-Spitzweg-Str. 61 | 90768 Fürth | Germany